Inquiry-Relative Categories: English Interjections as a Worked Case

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Abstract

Linguistic category disputes often combine different questions about the same expressions. I develop an account of inquiry-relative categories, using English interjections as a worked case. The account distinguishes useful descriptive classes from empirical categories whose co-occurring properties support induction for particular purposes. Expressive *Damn!* and depictive *Bang!* show why one inquiry into meaning can require several distinctions: conveying a stance and portraying a sound preserve different relations, despite similarities in grammatical distribution. Phonological resemblance likewise leaves grammatical membership unresolved. These comparisons locate the dispute in the inference being claimed: evidence can support a descriptive distinction without establishing category standing, and failure of one projection leaves independently supported distinctions intact. Several categories can serve one inquiry, just as one category can serve several inquiries. Their legitimacy depends on the inferences they support, making pluralism compatible with empirical grounds for rejecting particular proposals.

Keywords: inquiry-relative categories; category pluralism; projectibility; interjections; sign-types; path dependence

AI use. The large language models Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 5.5, GPT-5.6 Sol, GPT-6 Astra Pro, and GPT-6 (Codex) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

Standalone *Damn!*, complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!*, and prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* present different combinations of grammatical and semantic properties. The modifier participates in a noun phrase while retaining an expressive contribution. The standalone form can constitute a stance display. The complement-taking expression has internal structure even when the whole

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expression stands apart from a surrounding clause. A single judgment about whether *damn* is an interjection leaves these differences unresolved.

A comparison with depictive *Bang!* exposes a further distinction. The selected *damn* use conveys an evaluative stance; the selected *Bang!* depicts a sound. Both concern meaning, but they motivate different groupings and different questions about interpretation. Grouping one under semantics and the other under semiotics would do nothing to resolve those questions. Nor would calling both interjections establish that they share the relevant semantic properties.

This paper asks what warrants recognizing a category for an inquiry. An inquiry identifies a question and a standard of success; evidence constrains which grouping answers it. A field can pursue several inquiries, an inquiry can employ several categories, and a category can serve questions pursued across fields. English interjections make this many-to-many relation visible because grammatical, semantic, interactional, phonological, and historical descriptions repeatedly organize overlapping material.

A grouping can make measurement comparable or description informative. The distinctions among *damn* uses have descriptive value even before a new prediction is tested. Projectibility concerns the warrant for expectations beyond the evidence used to identify a case (Goodman, 1955). Neither descriptive usefulness nor a successful projection identifies its own causal explanation. These achievements need separate assessment.

Pluralism about useful and objectively grounded groupings has substantial precedents. Dupré (1993, pp. 5–7, 17–18) relates the choice of classification to the goals of inquiry while rejecting one uniquely privileged division of things. Khalidi (2013, pp. 63–64, 69–72) defends crosscutting kinds answering different epistemic interests. Their wider metaphysical commitments needn't all be adopted to recognize that distinct questions can require overlapping groupings.

Within linguistics, Haspelmath (2010, pp. 663, 666, 680) distinguishes language-particular descriptive categories from concepts designed for cross-language comparison. The division of labour here is different: several inquiries within English can organize the same expressions differently. The assessment developed here identifies where evidence for one claim leaves another unsupported. A semantic contrast can be preserved without establishing category-wide projections; phonological resemblance can leave grammatical membership unresolved. Specifying the bearer, grouping, and intended inference makes those transitions available for adjudication.

The worked cases are named for the relations they investigate: grammatical interjections, expressive signs, depictive signs, continuers, repair initiators, and closing formats. They needn't all operate at the same level of generality or retain an interjection label. In these comparisons, the common bearer is a conventionalized sign-type, an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Classifications of realizations or historical changes require explicit relations to these sign-types.

The historical case concerns path dependence: development can leave source-specific traces after uses converge. Gehweiler's history of *gee* supplies a documented explanation of one outcome; a verbal route to complement-taking *damn* remains partly reconstructive. The corpus material has a narrower role, showing how tags and strings can fail to identify the intended bearers. A linked supplement preserves the detailed measurement checks and two withdrawn confirmatory analyses.

Section 2 develops the named groupings and completes an expressive–depictive comparison. Section 3 distinguishes their possible achievements. Sections 4 and 5 apply the assessment to phonological and historical claims; Section 6 considers broader social and processing classes. The measure-

ment case and discussion then draw out what changes when the object, grouping, and claim are kept explicit.

2 Several groupings of conventional signs

Grammars and studies of meaning and interaction organize the traditional interjection domain differently. Jespersen (1924, p. 90) treated interjection as a manner in which words of other categories are used. *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*) recognizes a lexical category (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 22). The *Longman Grammar of Spoken and Written English* places interjections within the broader class of inserts, while assigning *damn*, *gosh*, and *gee* to expletives (Biber et al., 1999, pp. 1082–1083, 1094–1095).

The disputes concern a well-studied domain. Libert (2019) questions the description of interjections as neglected; Cram (2008, p. 63) identifies their recurring role in controversies over the syntax–pragmatics and semantics–pragmatics boundaries. The following comparisons preserve what those traditions distinguish without treating each tradition as the source of exactly one category.

2.1 Grammatical interjections and expressive signs

The grammatical proposal begins with standalone and supplement distribution. In *Damn, we're going to be late!*, *damn* is appended to the clause without being its complement or modifier. *CGEL* treats interjections as occurring on their own or functioning as supplements (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1350, 1361). In those conventional uses, they're characteristically invariant and resist the ordinary constituent positions available to nouns, verbs, or adjectives.

Supplement function is shared by several categories. Compare the interjection with the relative clause and noun phrase in these examples, adapted from *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1356–1357, 1360).

(1) a. *Ah, so you were there after all!*
b. *We called in to see Sue's parents, which made us rather late.*
c. *A university lecturer, Dr Brown, was arrested for the crime.*

Their external relation to a host leaves their internal grammatical differences intact. The same applies to *Damn these mosquitoes!*: the whole phrase's detachment is compatible with complementation inside it. *CGEL* tentatively treats the head as an exceptional interjection taking a noun-phrase complement (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 1361 n. 70). A verbal analysis remains a substantive alternative. Neither the complement nor the whole phrase's independence decides between them alone.

Prenominal *damn*, in *the damn car*, occurs inside the noun phrase while contributing an attitude toward its referent. Potts (2007, pp. 171, 182) distinguishes that expressive contribution from descriptive content. Grammatical integration leaves a semantic relation to standalone *Damn!* available for analysis. A single degree of interjectionhood would conceal which respect is shared and which differs.

The semantic grouping here is expressive signs: conventional uses whose deployment conveys an evaluative or affective stance, rather than merely describing that stance. This intended contribution is narrower than all non-descriptive or use-conditional meaning. A conventional instruction for managing interpretation or interaction needn't express such a stance. Potts's diagnostics include perspective dependence, immediacy, and intensifying repetition (Potts, 2007, pp. 166–167); whether they travel together across a proposed extension is an empirical question.

The grouping is broader than grammatical interjections. The examples in this paper are a selected part of it, chosen from disputes about interjections; that selection supplies no additional semantic membership condition. A broader account of expressives can include integrated signs with no traditional interjection label. Its descriptive benefit here is to preserve the expressive–descriptive distinction across independently identified grammatical constructions.

2.2 Expressive and depictive signs

Compare the selected expressive use of *Damn!* with a sound depiction *Bang!* in a narrative. The bearer in each case is the conventional use, not every occurrence of the spelling. The question is what contribution the use makes to interpretation. The strongest simple alternative groups both as expressive interjections on the basis of their vividness and standalone packaging. That alternative still has to explain the difference between conveying an attitude and presenting a sound.

A depictive sign conventionally presents a sound, event, or sensory scene through a resemblance between aspects of its performance and what it depicts. Dingemanse's account of ideophones supplies the wider comparison: conventional lexical items can depict sensory imagery, and their grammatical organization varies across languages (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 2–3). The term expressive is itself used for ideophones in some traditions; that usage doesn't identify them with Potts's expressives.

For the selected *Bang!*, the relevant contribution is a portrayal of an impact sound. For *Damn!*, it's the conveyed stance toward a situation. The distinction changes the interpretation of a possible modification. In a constructed narrative, *bang, bang, bang* can multiply portrayed impacts; repeated *damn* can strengthen the conveyed stance. Repetition can thus transform the contribution in different ways. These examples articulate the contrast to be explained; they aren't results from a new elicitation study.

The literature motivates those different targets. Potts treats repetition as potentially strengthening expressive contribution (Potts, 2007, pp. 181–182). Dingemanse connects depictive performance with iconic mappings between form and scene (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 10–11). An investigation can ask whether repetition changes portrayed event structure, conveyed stance, or both. It needn't assume one answer for every form traditionally called an interjection.

The descriptive comparison has a definite result. Separate expressive and depictive groupings preserve a difference in contribution that the undifferentiated alternative omits. A richer alternative could keep one superordinate class and record the difference as subtypes or dimensions. For this descriptive task, that's an acceptable equivalent if it retains the two relations. The result requires the distinction; it doesn't require a particular taxonomic rank.

Projective category standing remains a further question. Identifying a use as depictive from its interpretation under repetition and then predicting that interpretation from the label would recycle the admission evidence. An independent test could identify the use from unrepeated contexts and examine modifications elsewhere. Existing accounts motivate that comparison; the two illustrations don't establish a general response to repetition or a complete partition of semantic signs.

The groupings also needn't be disjoint. A depiction can convey an attitude, and an expressive performance can exploit resemblance. What matters is whether the relevant contribution is conventional in the selected use and what follows from it. Semantics can investigate both relations, or several more, without assigning each to a separate department or requiring one category to represent the semantic perspective as a whole.

2.3 Contribution, encoding, and competing analyses

Grouping by contribution differs from grouping by how that contribution is encoded. The depictive grouping already involves both a contribution and an iconic mode of presentation. The encoding question considered here is more specific: whether a sign supplies conceptual content or procedures guiding interpretation. An iconic presentation doesn't by itself decide between those accounts. Wharton (2016) develops a procedural account of expressive meaning, relating procedures for interpretation to the showing of emotion. On such an account, a sign can be expressive in its contribution and procedural in its encoding. Expressive and procedural aren't automatically complementary classes.

Three situations need separating. Expressive and depictive groupings can distinguish contributions within one inquiry. A grouping by contribution and another by mode of encoding can crosscut one another. But two accounts making incompatible claims about how the same sign encodes its meaning compete. Inquiry relativity doesn't adjudicate that competition; their divergent consequences require assessment against evidence.

An inquiry can also support finer groupings. Ameka (1992, p. 113) distinguishes emotive and cognitive subtypes within his expressive class: one concerns feelings or sensations, the other knowledge or recognition. His mental-state grouping is broader than the evaluative or affective stance grouping used above: cognitive contribution alone doesn't meet that narrower criterion. The subtypes illustrate another possible organization whose value depends on the generalizations being pursued.

2.4 Interactional resource classes

Continuers, repair initiators, and closing formats answer different interactional questions. A continuer such as *mm-hm* can support another speaker's ongoing turn. Repair *huh?* makes a response to a problem of hearing or understanding relevant. Closing *bye* participates in ending an encounter. Accounts of interjections in conversation make these sequential differences central (Dingemanse, 2024, pp. 257–259, 263–265).

For comparison, these can be collected as conventional action formats: non-elliptical resources that can perform their action without a lexically specified host. The working class collects resources whose particular sequential consequences still need separate characterization. Such predictions belong initially to particular resource classes and environments. The contribution of a superordinate interactional category would need separate support.

The criterion has consequences at the boundary. Response *okay* and closing or thanking *thanks* are candidates insofar as their selected uses conventionally perform the relevant action. A formulaic greeting *how are you?* can qualify despite having several words. An ordinary imperative *stop!* doesn't qualify merely because clause structure permits it to stand alone; a claim that it's also a conventional routine needs evidence beyond that structure.

Host-dependent *please* in *please sit down* belongs to a different comparison. A standalone appeal *Please!* would have to be assessed as that selected use. Thus the admission rule concerns conventional action formats, rather than brevity, wordhood, or every expression capable of being uttered alone. These constructed comparisons specify the proposal; they don't supply an annotated inventory.

The grammatical treatment of *mm-hm* and *huh?* likewise needs more than standalone occurrence. Ameka (1992, p. 114) includes the former among phatic interjections; Wilkins (1992, p. 152)

treats repair *huh?* as a conventional utterance. For the selected uses, I adopt the non-elliptical analysis: neither needs a recovered nominal head or clause to supply its interpretation. The grammatical assignments below are defeasible analyses supported by these descriptions, rather than deductions from punctuation.

Routine formulae expose competition within an inquiry. Ameka (1992, pp. 108–110) separates *bye*, *sorry*, and *thank you* from interjections, whereas Wilkins (1992, p. 142) treats routines as a subtype. Both attend to meaning and interaction. Assigning each a disciplinary label would misdescribe their disagreement. The selected closing format can be compared with continuers without settling whether the wider grouping is the most useful category for either question.

2.5 Common bearers and distinct questions

A sign-type is an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Its profile is the combination of grammatical, semantic, interactional, and other properties attributed to it. A use can retain its identity while a proposed property turns out to be absent. Otherwise every surprising observation would identify a different object and leave the original proposal immune to correction.

The recurrent contrast between standalone and prenominal *damn* supports distinguishing their conventional uses. In the complement-taking case, Table 1 classifies the lexical head *damn* in that construction. The whole phrase's external distribution is evidence about its environment, not a replacement bearer. The table records analytical judgments, not counts or results of a new annotation study.

Table 1: Selected conventional uses and the relations preserved by named analyses. The columns organize descriptions; they don't allocate one category to each field.

Selected bearer	Grammatical analysis	Meaning or action under comparison
gee!; stance *damn!*	Interjection	Expressive contribution; stance display
damn in *damn* + *NP*	Interjection head or verb: unresolved	Expressive contribution; the head's sequential affordances remain to be specified
Prenominal *damn*	Integrated modifier	Expressive contribution across a grammatical difference
Continuer *mm-hm*	Interjection analysis adopted	Continuation resource; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Repair *huh?*	Interjection analysis adopted	Open repair initiator; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Closing *bye*	Formulaic standalone expression	Closing resource
Depictive *Bang!*	Interjection or nominal-fragment analysis: unresolved	Sound depiction; stance is a separate question

Several analyses can assign the same selected uses for different reasons. The examples establish expressive commonality across a grammatical difference and different contributions within a semantic comparison. They leave the overall relation between the grammatical and interactional extensions

open. Agreement over selected cases neither supplies an extensional separation nor settles how far the groupings coincide.

Bang! makes the unresolved grammatical question concrete. English also has nominal *bang*, as in the constructed *a loud bang* and *two bangs*. A standalone occurrence needs assessment against a nominal-fragment analysis. Its depictive interpretation can be recognized while that question remains open. Section 4 completes the related assessment of what phonological evidence can decide.

3 What warrants a class, a category, or an explanation?

The expressive–depictive comparison establishes a descriptive distinction. Whether either grouping supports further induction is a different question. The same distinction applies to grammatical and interactional proposals: an inventory can organize the observed uses accurately while leaving its reach beyond those observations unknown. A common assessment should recognize both the value of that description and the additional commitment made when an empirical category is proposed.

3.1 Bearers, grouping, contribution, and alternatives

Four questions organize the assessment. What bears membership? What groups the members? What does the grouping help an investigator distinguish, infer, or explain? And what alternative would serve the same inquiry? Each proposal also needs a scope: a language or community, relevant conditions, and, where the claim concerns change, a period. These questions apply to established proposals and new candidates alike.

The bearer is the object grouped. Here it can be a conventional sign-type; a phonologist may instead group realizations, and a historian may group changes linking earlier and later signs. A frequency of realizations doesn't immediately establish a number of types or a rate of change. The grammatical category of a head likewise differs from the external distribution of its containing phrase.

The grouping basis is the evidence or relation used to assign members: distribution, expressive contribution, ancestry, or participation in a recognized repertoire, for example. A grouping can be sharp or graded and can use one diagnostic or several. A unique mechanism isn't a prerequisite for stating the proposal. Whether the proposed members support any particular induction or explanation remains to be assessed.

The contribution identifies what the grouping accomplishes. A constructed class can fix a comparison set. A descriptive class can organize a recurrent relation across independently identified cases. A category claim requires evidence that co-occurring properties support induction beyond the application conditions. A causal claim requires evidence about the process producing an outcome. These achievements can accumulate, but evidence for an earlier one doesn't establish a later one automatically.

Descriptive success can be assessed without requiring a prediction about a differently named property. The expressive grouping preserves a semantic relation across standalone and integrated constructions; the expressive–depictive contrast records different contributions concealed by the broad cover term. Those are warranted uses of descriptive classes. Calling them descriptions doesn't diminish their scientific value. It specifies the achievement so that categoryhood, in the stronger sense used here, remains an answerable further question.

An alternative can be a broader class, narrower subtypes, a continuous dimension, or an item-by-item account. In the worked semantic comparison, separate classes and a superordinate class with explicit subtypes both preserve the decisive distinction. For an inquiry into recipient responses,

action-specific groupings may be more informative than their union. The number and rank of categories are outcomes of comparison, rather than requirements supplied by a field or inquiry.

Table 2: Assessing the expressive grouping without conflating its achievements

Question	Proposed answer	Evidential consequence
Bearer	Conventional uses, including standalone and prenominal *damn*	Identify each use without requiring the target property under investigation.
Grouping	Deployment conventionally conveys evaluative or affective stance	Distinguish this from describing an emotion, depicting a scene, or managing interaction.
Contribution	Preserve expressive commonality across grammatical constructions	Distinguish the observed contrast from its extension to new realizations, environments, or sign-types.
Alternative	An undifferentiated interjection class, explicit subtypes, or item-specific accounts	Compare which semantic relations each preserves and what further generalization each warrants.

3.2 From proposal to category claim

An admission rule fixes which cases enter a class. A category claim makes a further commitment: membership supports informative expectations beyond the evidence used to assign it. Assembling a grouping and warranting those expectations can succeed or fail separately. Here, category standing names the latter achievement; it isn't a verdict on whether a descriptive class is scientifically useful.

The reach of an expectation needs specifying. Evidence about a familiar sign can warrant expectations about new realizations or environments. Extending an expressive contrast to another construction can already involve induction. This establishes reach for that sign without by itself warranting the same expectation for another sign-type. A category-level projection can make that further commitment about an independently identified member.

The target needn't be a differently named property. A familiar property in a new environment can provide informative reach if it wasn't part of the admission evidence. Assigning expressive uses by their stance in one construction and investigating how that contribution behaves elsewhere differs from defining the class to contain only uses already known to exhibit the target behavior.

An additional shared property isn't sufficient merely because it's additional. If all members and nearly every sign outside a proposed grouping exhibit the target repetition behavior, membership supplies little additional guidance about it. An imperfect probabilistic association can be informative when it changes a warranted expectation at the stated scope. The alternatives in the preceding section help assess that contribution.

This comparison concerns what membership licenses an investigator to expect. Whether a category representation improves a particular model is a separate question, taken up below. Projective warrant doesn't require that representation to outperform every account of the same evidence. Both claims remain limited to the profile and scope tested: support for a subtype doesn't automatically extend to its superordinate class.

I provisionally accept the grammatical and action-specific categories used here for the relations documented in the cited descriptions. This inherits their evidential warrant at that scope; it doesn't establish every extension considered here. The present comparisons defend expressive and depictive distinctions and reject an unsupported transfer from phonology to grammar. They leave the broader projective standing of the proposed semantic, phonological, and ancestry groupings open.

3.3 Projection and identity

A projective claim states what's been observed, what's expected, and over which bearers and conditions. Its warrant is the evidence supporting that expectation (Goodman, 1955). A precise specification can have little warrant; a reliable association can remain causally unexplained. The content, evidential status, and proposed ground of a claim need separate assessment (Reynolds, 2026, pp. 11–12).

Suppose source contexts identify an expressive use and the target is its interpretation under repetition. Repetition can't also supply the case-level evidence used to admit that use. Similarly, if resistance to determiner combination is the target, an unexpected determiner can't by itself justify excluding the case as conversion. A change to the identification rule creates a revised claim requiring assessment.

Consider a hypothetical adverse case for standalone stance *damn*. The initial identification uses its conventional reaction meaning and recurrence across independently sampled situations; the grammatical prediction concerns resistance to integration. A new occurrence retains that reaction meaning but functions as an integrated dependent of a larger constituent. The first response is to check that structural analysis. If it stands, the occurrence counts against the proposed distribution under the original identification rule. Its inconvenience isn't evidence for a second sign.

Evaluate the original projection under the identification rule available when it was made. Later evidence may warrant distinguishing a recurrent conventional use by its contribution or distribution. That revision can improve subsequent predictions, but it doesn't remove earlier counterexamples from the original assessment. Observations that motivate a new distinction don't also supply independent confirmation of its predictive success.

A quoted token or a productive noun denoting an utterance remains another possible analysis, but it needs evidence for quotation or nominal reference. A correction to a mistaken structural analysis should be recorded as such. It differs from changing the identification rule so that a confirmed counterexample no longer falls within its scope.

An informative restriction also needs relevant opportunities. Failure to observe inflection says little if the sampled environments wouldn't elicit it under a rival analysis. A grammatical test needs source and target constructions; an interactional test needs actions and sequential environments. The common bearer allows these claims to concern the same use. It doesn't make their evidence interchangeable.

3.4 Representation and causal explanation

A category label computed deterministically from fully observed features adds no information to those features. A representation can still help an investigator working with incomplete or noisy observations: it can support pooling, reduce separate assumptions, or express relevant dependencies. Such benefits require a comparison for the specified task. They don't establish that the represented grouping has a unique causal ground.

Intersections receive the same treatment. A joint grouping can be economical even though its membership follows from the component assignments. An advantage over one restricted model wouldn't give it priority for every inquiry. Conversely, derivability alone doesn't make it useless. The comparison needs to identify what the alternatives retain and what the investigator needs to infer.

A historical explanation can remain informative after present structure is fully observed. If recruitment produced that structure, conditioning on it can remove the association through which the history is recognized. A test of additional prediction from present evidence differs from a test of the proposed history. For processing, too, conditioning on measured frequency doesn't by itself identify repetition's total or direct causal contribution to retrieval.

Hill (1965, pp. 295–299) offered viewpoints for comparing causal interpretations with alternatives, including temporal order and consistency with independently supported knowledge. They concern specified causes and outcomes; they neither establish category standing nor form a mechanical checklist. Section 5 applies the temporal question to *gee*. Recurrence alone identifies neither a causal ordering nor a process that maintains a profile.

4 Phonological organization and situated realization

Phonological evidence already enters descriptions of interjections in two forms. Some signs permit sounds or combinations unusual elsewhere in a variety; particular occurrences also have distinctive prosodic packaging. These observations motivate different classifications. The first can group sign-types by their phonological possibilities. The second groups realizations by how speakers produce them in context. Their relation is empirically interesting precisely because they don't classify the same objects.

4.1 A phonological stratum of signs

English conversational clicks make the first possibility concrete. The click represented by *tut-tut* differs from an ordinary spelling pronunciation (Wilkins, 1992, p. 147). Forms such as *ugh* permit sounds outside the usual phoneme inventory of standard British and American English (Quirk et al., 1985, p. 853). A phonological inquiry can ask which conventional signs admit such resources, how their variants are organized, and how speakers acquire or adapt them.

Ameka (1992, pp. 112–113) diagnoses a specific inference: unusual phonology shared with interjections has been used to include onomatopoeic words in the grammatical interjection category. His alternative is to recognize a phonological grouping whose members can belong to different grammatical categories. The following assessment develops the evidential consequence of that distinction.

The grammatical claim concerns membership in a lexical category. The evidence offered concerns sounds or sound patterns unusual elsewhere in the language. That evidence supports a comparison of phonological possibilities across independently identified signs. By itself, it doesn't settle whether a particular use has nominal, verbal, or interjectional grammar. Nor does sound depiction itself entail phonological anomaly: resemblance and distribution within the sound system are different relations.

Phonological evidence can support a grammatical expectation where an independently established association warrants it. The shared unusualness considered here doesn't itself establish that association. The limitation concerns the evidence connecting the properties, not the fact that they belong to different domains.

For English *Bang!*, the competing grammatical analysis is a standalone nominal fragment, supported as a possibility by the independently available noun in *a loud bang*. A depictive interpretation

leaves that analysis open. Even if an occurrence had unusual phonation, the additional observation would concern its realization. Choosing between nominal and interjectional analyses needs distributional and constructional evidence about the selected conventional use, or an independently warranted association connecting the observed phonology to that grammar.

The strongest alternative retains one broad descriptive class and records phonology and grammar as separate attributes. For organizing known cases, that can preserve the same information. It becomes inadequate only if membership in the broad class is used to infer a grammatical assignment without the relevant evidence. The assessment rejects that inference while retaining the cross-grammatical phonological comparison. It doesn't establish a single projectible phonological stratum.

An account of the stratum would gain projective reach if membership organized acquisition, adaptation, or alternation beyond the diagnostic used to identify it. For example, a class based on independently established segmental possibilities could be assessed against patterns of spelling pronunciation. That's a prospective comparison. The existence of unusual sounds and reported alternatives establishes a descriptive motivation; it doesn't yet show one phonological class with a uniform learning or adaptation profile.

Regular phonology matters too. In a ten-language study of open repair interjections, Dingemanse et al. (2013) find broad phonetic similarities alongside language-specific vowel targets and intonation. The repair interjections in Icelandic and Cha'palaa have falling contours, consistent with local interrogative prosody. The study concerns comparable repair environments. It supplies no reason to assign every occurrence resembling *huh* to one phonologically exceptional class.

Phonological classification thus has work to do within ordinary linguistic organization as well as at its margins. An inquiry into repair intonation could group forms with interrogative resources; another into unusual segments could group conversational clicks with other marked forms. Both could be useful. A single label such as PHONOLOGICAL INTERJECTION would obscure the difference unless the inquiry and grouping basis were specified.

4.2 Prosodic classes of realizations

A prosodic boundary is a property of a realization. A sign-type can characteristically occupy its own intonation phrase while allowing different realizations in different environments. Conversely, realizations of grammatically different signs can share a boundary pattern. Supplements provide a familiar example: interjections, noun phrases, and relative clauses can all be prosodically detached (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 66, 1350).

The relation can be stated in two steps. First identify an occurrence as a realization of a sign-type using evidence appropriate to that identification. Then classify its prosodic organization from the acoustic record. A claim about the sign-type concerns the distribution of those realizations over relevant environments. One detached occurrence is evidence about a possibility; an adequately sampled distribution is needed for a claim about what's characteristic.

Interaction supplies some of those environments. Ogden (2013) describes English clicks and percussives in stance-taking, sequence management, word searches, and turn timing, with visual behaviour contributing to their interpretation. A classification of productions by timing and articulation can intersect an analysis of sequential practices. The range of jobs also cautions against assigning one conventional action or expressive meaning to every click.

Written corpora provide indirect access to this relation. Punctuation and standalone position can indicate detachment, but editorial conventions and genre affect both. Using the same comma

as evidence for prosodic isolation and syntactic independence can't then establish an independently observed association between the two. The phonological and grammatical inquiries may converge, but the evidence for their convergence has to preserve the distinction between their measures.

The two phonological inquiries extend the family in different ways. Phonological strata can share their sign-type bearers and enter membership intersections. Prosodic classes of occurrences connect to them through realization and through distributions over contexts. Treating both as extra columns in the same sign-type table would hide the relation that the phonological inquiry is meant to explain.

5 Historical ancestry and classes of change

A historical classification asks how signs came to have their present properties. Signs with different current distributions can descend from related sources, while signs with similar current profiles can arrive by different routes. The inquiry can classify present signs by independently established ancestry. It can also classify historical changes, such as clipping or reanalysis. The first has sign-types as bearers; the second has changes linking sources and outcomes.

5.1 The documented route to *gee*

Gehweiler (2008) traces *gee* through an invocation of *Jesus*, an exclamatory use of the religious name, and a clipped form. In the invocation, the speaker addresses the deity. The exclamation can express a reaction without that address. Clipping then produces a form whose relation to the name can become opaque. The sequence separates semantic change from the later change of form.

The transitions also have different proposed explanations. Gehweiler relates the first to gradual invited inference, aided by the syntactically peripheral invocation. She analyzes the clipping as an abrupt, taboo-motivated change involving hearer reanalysis (Gehweiler, 2008, pp. 84–88). The source invocation already permits peripheral packaging. Its development gives no reason to assume that a new prosodic boundary caused the semantic transition or that all the properties changed together.

The history explains why the shape of *gee* bears a relation to religious invocation even for a speaker who doesn't recognize that relation. Its present opacity alone wouldn't identify its ancestry. The documented sequence supplies the additional evidence for a restricted instance of path dependence: a particular route helps explain a feature of its outcome, without making every other outcome of that route predictable.

The explanation concerns a particular outcome. It doesn't yet establish that a class of signs with religious ancestry outperforms alternatives or supports a common projection. That comparison would require independently documented histories and outcomes across more than this one route.

Hill's considerations clarify a tempting stronger claim. If newly acquired prosodic isolation were proposed as a cause of the semantic change, the already peripheral invocation would fail to supply the required change in exposure. The cited history doesn't independently measure a prosodic innovation preceding the semantic transition. Plausibility of a prosody–syntax connection can't supply that missing temporal comparison. An already present peripheral construction could still be an enabling condition for later change. Gehweiler's proposed roles for invited inference and taboo-motivated clipping remain distinct historical claims with their own evidence.

The distinction also corrects an ambiguity in PRIMARY and SECONDARY interjections. Ameka's distinction concerns whether a form has other, non-interjectional uses in the language (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). It isn't a partition into historically underived and historically derived signs. Geh-

weiler's primary *gee* has a documented derived history. Conversely, an unknown etymology supplies a gap in knowledge, not a common origin shared by all forms whose sources remain unknown.

5.2 Source, mechanism, transmission, and trajectory

A useful historical description separates four relations. The SOURCE identifies an earlier sign or construction. The MECHANISM specifies a change, such as clipping or reanalysis. The TRANSMISSION SETTING concerns how the innovation spreads, including borrowing where supported. The subsequent TRAJECTORY concerns further changes in use or form. Signs can share one relation without sharing the other three.

For *gee*, a religious invocation supplies the source and tabooistic clipping supplies one mechanism. Those facts don't establish the transmission history of every later community's use. Nor does a shared source force a common trajectory: an exclamatory religious name can remain phonologically close to its source without later undergoing clipping. Historical classes can be organized at several levels, according to which relation the inquiry needs.

The proposed verbal route to complement-taking *damn* illustrates unequal support among histories. *God damn him* has the shape of an optative, a construction independently recognized in English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 944). Omission of the subject and increasing conventional expressive force offer a plausible route to *damn him*. The surviving complement fits that reconstruction. These synchronic comparisons don't establish the sequence as independently as Gehweiler's historical record does.

The source optative already uses plain-form *damn*, so the reconstruction doesn't require loss of tense marking at that transition. And the present complement remains compatible with competing analyses of the head as verbal or interjectional. A classification by independently established verbal ancestry could cross that present grammatical boundary. Inferring the ancestry solely from the complement and then invoking the ancestry to predict that same complement would be circular.

Classes of changes require a different representation. An instance of clipping relates an earlier form to an outcome; an instance of semantic reanalysis relates earlier and later interpretations. Neither is itself a sign-type alongside *gee* and *damn*. A process classification can support comparisons among developments, while explicit source–result relations connect those developments to classifications of their inputs and outputs.

5.3 What historical evidence can establish

Historical explanation and forward projection need different comparisons. A documented route may explain a present feature through the changes that produced it. A forward projection asks what information about the route warrants expecting in another case. For a verbal-source class, that target could concern surviving restrictions on dependents, provided those restrictions weren't used to assign the source. The present examples motivate that inquiry without establishing a category-wide result.

Evidence for replication also needs to distinguish innovations from their descendants. Several communities' uses of a borrowed sign can be several outcomes of one innovation, rather than independent instances of a recruitment route. They may support an account of transmission or subsequent divergence. They provide a weaker comparison for the claim that the same source independently produces the same result. The sampling unit depends on which historical claim is at issue.

An ancestry classification can still explain a present contrast even when ancestry adds no predictive information after all its consequences are observed. Conditioning on those consequences changes the question to whether ancestry contributes anything further. That can be a useful test of predictive economy; it isn't a general test of whether the documented process occurred or helped produce the contrast.

Historical classes can have two kinds of payoff. They can organize independently supported source relations among present signs, and they can compare processes across developments. These are legitimate descriptive and explanatory contributions. An empirical ancestry category, in the stronger usage adopted here, also needs support for the inductions it licenses. The documented history of one sign can't supply that support for an entire source class.

6 Broader classes and further inquiries

The traditional interjection domain also intersects classes whose most informative members lie elsewhere. Social regulation can group forms by their appropriateness for audiences and settings. Processing inquiries can group familiar expressions by how they're produced or understood. An interjection's membership in either class needn't make the class interjection-specific. Three questions remain distinct: whether the broader class is supported, how it intersects the traditional domain, and whether an INTERJECTION label helps describe that intersection.

6.1 Social regulation and socially recognized repertoires

Religious exclamations make social regulation relevant to the worked case. In Gehweiler's account, taboo pressure contributes to clipping *Jesus* into *gee*. A present-day inquiry might instead group uses according to their evaluated appropriateness for an audience or setting. The historical cause of an innovation and the current regulation of its descendants are separate targets; evidence for one doesn't settle the other.

Jay and Janschewitz (2008) examine ratings of hypothetical swearing scenarios, finding that judgments depend on the word, speaker–listener relations, and social and physical context. Such evidence supports contextual differentiation in evaluations of taboo language. It doesn't directly observe sanctions or show that corrective responses maintain a class of interjections. Those stronger proposals would need their own measures of behaviour and change.

Social indexing poses a related but distinct inquiry. Agha's account of enregisterment concerns the social recognition of speech forms as indexing attributes of speakers, with a repertoire's associations and social reach subject to change (Agha, 2005, pp. 38–40). A classification by participation in a recognized repertoire could cross grammatical, semantic, and sequential divisions. The relevant evidence concerns recognition and use of those associations, beyond a frequency difference between geographical collections.

These social classifications can matter even where the sequential action stays constant. Two forms might both register surprise while carrying different audience-sensitive evaluations. Conversely, one socially marked repertoire can include forms used for several actions. The intended contribution determines whether to group conventional sign-types, uses in a specified community, or particular selections in context. Where conventions differ by community, that scope belongs in the identification of the bearer.

6.2 Formulaicity and processing

Formulaicity offers a similarly broad comparison. A familiar greeting, a pause filler, and an idiom may share aspects of conventionalized production while differing in grammar and conversational function. An inquiry into their processing can group them on grounds that cross the grammatical, semantic, and interactional groupings developed earlier. Its appropriate name may be formulaic expressions, with an explicitly described interjectional intersection.

Van Lancker Sidtis et al. (2015) report differences in formulaic language production and comprehension across clinical groups and healthy participants. Their production analysis combines six kinds of formulaic material, including conversational formulae, pause fillers, sentence stems, and idioms. The results give empirical consequences to that broader organization. They don't isolate an interjection-specific processing class or locate a neural basis for grammatical interjections, expressive signs, or particular interactional resources.

An investigation of a narrower class would need an independently motivated grouping and a specified processing contrast. Frequency, familiarity, conventional meaning, and contextual predictability are possible contributors to fluent retrieval. Their roles depend on the question. If repeated use is proposed to help establish the routine, statistical adjustment for measured frequency needs care. The resulting conditional association identifies a causal contribution only under additional assumptions about exposure, retrieval, and their relation to the measure.

Evidence of different processing can also cut across a proposed class. A formulaicity measure might explain performance better than membership in any interjection category. That would favour the broader or continuous representation for this inquiry. The grammatical contrast between a filler and an idiom would remain available to an inquiry into syntax. Local comparative failure has a definite consequence without erasing independently supported distinctions elsewhere.

6.3 Keeping the family open without multiplying labels

Other inquiries are easy to motivate, but motivation alone doesn't establish their proposed categories. Table 3 identifies several candidates and the contribution each would need to specify. The table is an agenda for distinguishing questions. It makes no claim that every row identifies a single class, that their extensions are independent, or that all deserve an interjection label.

Morphology illustrates the distinctions within a row. The absence of an inflectional paradigm differs from resistance to derivation. A retained plural shape in exclamatory *heavens!* differs from a productive number contrast. Attested noun and verb uses of *ouch* in child-directed speech show why a claim about invariance needs to specify the conventional use (Stange, 2016, p. 36). These facts motivate several comparisons, without supplying one morphological definition of interjectionhood.

Semiotic and graphic inquiries can likewise cross familiar boundaries. A depiction can be realized as a conventional spoken sign or an inscription, while an inscription can also represent a speaker's production. Work on ideophones distinguishes depictive resources from the predominantly indexical relation associated with interjections (Dingemanse, 2018; Dingemanse & Akita, 2017). Whether a particular graphic form is a transcription, an autonomous convention, or both requires evidence about its use; resemblance alone doesn't decide.

Developmental and multimodal inquiries can change the bearer more radically. An acquisition episode has participants and a temporal course. A situated vocal–visual performance includes coordination that a lexical sign-type doesn't exhaust. Classifying either can be informative, provided

Table 3: Further inquiries and their possible bearers

Inquiry	Possible bearer	Contribution requiring assessment
Morphological organization	Sign-types in identified constructions	Distinguish invariance, productive operations, and retained source material.
Semiotic relations	Conventional signs, or sign–referent relations	Organize depiction, indexing, and conventional meaning across grammatical categories.
Development and learning	Learners' repertoires or acquisition episodes	Identify acquisition patterns without equating a learner's repertoire with an adult inventory.
Multimodal organization	Conventional complexes or situated performances	Explain contributions of vocal and visible components and their coordination.
Graphic communication	Written sign-types or particular inscriptions	Distinguish conventional graphic forms from representations of spoken realizations.
Annotation	Tokens under a stated coding scheme	Support reliable retrieval or comparison for the scheme's task.

the connection to the sign-type inventory is made through learning or realization relations. Their classes can't be intersected directly with a set of signs as though all were objects of the same kind.

Annotation makes the practical stakes clear. A tag can be useful for retrieving conversational responses even if its extension combines several grammatical or semantic classes. Its success is then measured against the retrieval task and coding policy. That success doesn't establish a lexical category. Conversely, poor retrieval under a particular tag says little about the existence of a distinction the tagging scheme wasn't designed to record.

7 A measurement case: tags, strings, and uses

A corpus query can identify a useful class without recovering the intended linguistic bearers. The Corpus of Global Web-Based English (GloWbE) contains country-labelled web sections (Davies & Fuchs, 2015). An interjection tag, the string *ha*, and a conventional interjectional use of *ha* select different sets. Confusing them can turn a retrieval convention into apparent evidence about a category.

The *ha* record makes the consequence concrete. Some tagged occurrences abbreviate HECTARE, especially in agricultural prose. A rule-based screen of exported contexts changes Kenya's rank from fifth to fifteenth or sixteenth under six treatments of laughter and unclear cases; pooling gives ranks from fourteenth to sixteenth. The large movement is stable across those choices. Its exact size remains conditional on the screen and on the exported samples.

The screen was tuned against forty Kenyan and Tanzanian examples; its resulting 39/40 binary agreement is a development check. It doesn't establish equivalent accuracy in every country section. The observed geographic distribution depends on both the linguistic phenomenon and the measurement procedure. An analysis of category variation would need independently identified uses and comparable opportunities for their occurrence.

Similarly, changing frequency ranks in the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA) describe a tagged inventory (Davies, 2010). They don't establish persistence of a semantic or grammatical profile. Two further analyses, of derivatives and *fie*, fail their intended confirmatory interpretation: the primary derivative pipeline assigned semantic residue rather than measuring it, and the *fie* input retained ineligible optical character recognition substitutions. Their confirmatory claims are withdrawn.

The evidence supplement preserves the complete records: GloWbE measurement and model comparisons (Section A), the derivative audit (Section B), the *fie* audit (Section C), and inventory turnover (Section D). Its retained model comparison predicts an omitted country–item cell within the observed design; it doesn't assess new countries, new items, or the proposed linguistic groupings. These records locate the failure at the relevant claim. A useful retrieval class survives as a tool, but its output can't establish a linguistic category without evidence connecting that class to independently identified uses.

8 The general consequence

Named groupings expose what a broad interjection judgment can obscure. The grammatical analysis of prenominal *damn* concerns its integration into the noun phrase; the expressive analysis concerns its contribution to interpretation. Depictive *Bang!* poses another semantic question. Continuers and repair initiators organize different sequential environments. These relations needn't fit a fixed matrix with one column for each discipline.

8.1 Many-to-many relations and local failure

Dupré's pluralism and Khalidi's crosscutting kinds make room for multiple defensible groupings. The linguistic cases add a practical requirement: specify which relation a proposed grouping preserves and which objects participate in it. Haspelmath's division between descriptive categories and comparative concepts supplies a related lesson about analytical purpose. Here, the same care is needed within a language and within an inquiry.

The expressive–depictive comparison establishes that several groupings can be useful for one question about meaning contribution. A procedural account asks a different question about encoding, potentially cutting across those groupings. If two encoding accounts conflict, the conflict remains. Neither putting them in different fields nor assigning each a new label makes their claims compatible.

Failure has correspondingly local consequences. A grouping can lack reliable application conditions, obscure the stated descriptive contrast, or fail to support a projected property. A historical explanation can lack independently supported source evidence. Revising the grouping or the question creates a new proposal; it doesn't preserve the support of a failed claim. Other distinctions survive only where they have their own evidence.

This discipline also limits positive conclusions. The semantic comparison favours preserving expressive and depictive contributions, while leaving open whether separate classes, subtypes, or dimensions best serve a further task. The phonological comparison rejects an unsupported transfer to grammatical membership. The *gee* history supports a particular explanation. These are substantive outcomes without a claim that this paper has validated a complete family of empirical categories.

8.2 Overlap, mechanisms, and category standing

For common bearers, intersections are well-defined and may be useful. Their value depends on the task and alternatives, including representations of separate memberships and their dependencies. No automatically privileged category follows from an overlap among grammatical interjections, expressives, and interactional resources. Nor is a useful intersection excluded merely because its membership can be derived.

Distinct categories needn't be statistically independent, and they can share causal processes. Strong correlation doesn't make two questions identical; a shared history doesn't establish every present property. A causal network is one possible account, provided its variables and links have independent support. Hill's considerations help assess specified causal interpretations; they don't turn covariation into a mechanism by being applied to a diagram.

Gradience is another separate issue. A class can have graded membership, sharp subtypes, or unresolved cases due to missing evidence. A prototype account organizes typicality and similarity (Rosch, 1975; Taylor, 2003). The assessment here asks what such organization accomplishes and what it licenses an investigator to infer. Either a prototype or a categorical representation can serve a task; neither gains empirical category standing from its form alone.

A field supplies no fixed quota of categories, and an inquiry needn't end with just one. A grouping may serve several questions across fields, but warrant only specified projections under specified conditions. The historical label INTERJECTION identifies a meeting point for these inquiries. The evidence, rather than the label or departmental boundary, determines which proposed categories deserve recognition.

9 Conclusion

English interjections expose a general difference between assembling a class and establishing an empirical category. Descriptive classes can make contrasts visible; category claims require co-occurring properties that support induction for particular purposes. Explanations require further evidence about how an outcome arose or is maintained. These achievements should be assessed for named groupings, not allocated in advance to grammar, semantics, and pragmatics.

The expressive–depictive comparison shows why one semantic inquiry can need several groupings. The phonological case shows why evidence for one grouping leaves a different membership question open. A history can explain an outcome without validating an ancestry category, and a corpus tag can aid retrieval without identifying the intended sign-types. In each case, making the bearer, grouping basis, and intended contribution explicit changes what would count as support or counterevidence. An undifferentiated category judgment conceals those differences; the account developed here makes them available for adjudication.

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